



GABRIELA HASBUN For The Times

THEY CAN DO IT

Angel Greer, from left, Rennae Ross, Nicci Whetam and Jocelyn Mak are among the volunteers paying tribute to Rosie the Riveter as they restore a WWII ship turned museum in the Bay Area. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

From Lamborghinis to lockup

Ex-LAPD officer is accused of staging a crypto heist with a reputed Israeli mob figure. He was already facing a fraud probe.

BY LIBOR JANY AND RICHARD WINTON

In December 2021, Eric Benjamin Halem was riding high. Beyond his day job as an LAPD officer, he was juggling several lucrative side hustles, business records and court filings show. Private security. An app for aspiring actors trying to land auditions. And an exotic car rental company, Drive-LA, that was gaining a following among rappers, influencers and executives. But Halem's comfortable life soon began to unravel. He left his full-time position with the LAPD after coming

under internal investigation, according to records submitted as part of a lawsuit. Earlier this year, state authorities charged him with insurance fraud. Then, a few weeks ago, L.A. County prosecutors accused him of masterminding a home invasion robbery with a man with reputed ties to the Israeli underworld — part of what authorities say is a growing trend of criminals targeting victims for their cryptocurrency profits. How Halem, 37, became embroiled with one of his alleged co-conspirators,

Gaby (sometimes spelled "Gabby") Ben, remains a mystery. Ben, who has twice been convicted of fraud, was a close business associate of Moshe Matsri, or "Moshe the Religious," whom authorities describe as an L.A. leader of the Israeli underground who had long operated in the San Fernando Valley and had ties to the Abergil crime syndicate, according to court filings. In the early morning hours of Dec. 28, 2024, Halem, Ben and Mishael [See Officer, A6]

Summer flicks fall flat again at the box office

Recent revenue reached \$3.67 billion, just below the \$3.68 billion tallied in 2024.

BY SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

Stitch, Superman and a flock of creepy children drew audiences to movie theaters this summer, but it wasn't enough to jolt box office revenue past even the dreary levels reached last year. The total theatrical haul for the summer — which, for industry watchers, stretches from the first weekend of May through Labor Day — grossed \$3.67 billion in the U.S. and Canada, down slightly from \$3.68 billion in 2024, according to Comscore. The numbers are even more sobering compared with 2023's Barbenheimer-fueled summer sum of \$4 billion, a target the industry used to hit routinely. Though the season started with high hopes after spring hits including "Sinners" and "A Minecraft Movie," and particularly since there were several big franchise blockbusters on the lineup, the softer summer shows cracks in the movie business that have been growing for years. Theaters have been grappling with declining attendance since before the pandemic, though the COVID-19-related shutdowns exacerbated that trend. Not only did audiences get used to streaming movies from home, but certain mid-tier films, such as comedies, increasingly mi-

grated over to those platforms, making them rarer sights at the box office. Studios continue to suffer from an overreliance on franchises that are losing steam. A series of massive hits can change the mood, but those were lacking this summer. For starters, no single film emerged as an unstoppable hit on the level of last year's Walt Disney Co. and Pixar animated sequel "Inside Out 2" and Marvel Studios' "Deadpool & Wolverine," which each hauled in more than \$600 million domestically (and had global grosses exceeding \$1 billion). Disney's live-action adaptation of "Lilo & Stitch" [See Box office, A7]

Migrant kids put on planes can stay, for now

In the predawn hours, a federal judge halts Texas flights to deport minors to Guatemala.

BY VALERIE GONZALEZ, REBECCA SANTANA AND JENNIFER PELTZ

HARLINGEN, Texas — With migrant children waiting on tarmacs to be sent to their native Guatemala, a federal judge Sunday temporarily blocked the flights, siding with attorneys for the children who said the government was breaking laws and sending their clients to potential peril. The extraordinary drama played out over predawn hours on the Labor Day weekend and vaulted from tarmacs in Texas to a courtroom in Washington. It was the latest showdown over the Trump administration's crackdown on immigration — and the latest high-stakes clash between the administration's enforcement efforts and legal safeguards that Congress created for vulnerable migrants. Guatemalan children who arrived at the border without their parents or guardians will stay for at least two weeks while the legal fight unfolds, according to the ruling. "I do not want there to be any ambiguity," said U.S. District Judge Sparkle L. Sooknanan. "This idea that on a long weekend in the dead of night they would wake up these vulnerable children and put them on a plane irrespective of the constitutional protections that they had is something that should shock the conscience of all Americans," said Kica Matos, president of the National Immigration Law Center, which represents the children, after Sunday's hearing. The Homeland Security Department did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the ruling. The chaotic, rapid-fire developments resembled a March weekend showdown over the deportation of hundreds of Venezuelans to a maximum-security prison in El Salvador. Advocates implored a federal judge to halt deportations they believed were imminent, while the Trump administration was silent about its plans. In that case, the judge appeared in civilian clothes for a Saturday night hearing and tried to block the flights, but they went ahead, with the government saying the [See Planes, A7]

National park workers in California unionize

Vote at Yosemite, Sequoia and Kings Canyon comes after mass firing by Trump.

BY LILA SEIDMAN

For two years, labor organizers tried to unionize employees at a trio of celebrated California national parks, but they couldn't reach critical mass. Then came mass firings of National Park Service employees in February under the Trump administration. Many employees were reinstated, but litigation

concerning the legality of the firings winds on. The park service has lost about a quarter of its staff since Trump reclaimed the White House, and that's on top of a proposed \$1-billion budget cut to the agency. This summer the scales tipped. More than 97% of employees at Yosemite and Sequoia and Kings Canyon national parks who cast ballots voted to unionize, with results certified last week. More than 600 staffers — including interpretive park rangers, biologists, firefighters and fee collectors — are now represented by the National Federation of Federal Employees.

"Culture is hard to change," said Steven Gutierrez, a national business representative for the union. "It takes something like this administration firing people to wake people up, to say, 'Hey, I'm vulnerable here and I need to invest in my career.' " The unionized employees work at some of California's most celebrated and highly visited national parks. Yosemite is famous for its awe-inspiring valley, while Sequoia and Kings Canyon are known for their giant sequoia trees. Amid that beauty is a workforce that is frustrated and fearful. Two employees [See Unionization, A12]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

UNION representative Steven Gutierrez says the parks' federal workers are not allowed to go on strike.



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

A NEW VISION AT LACMA

The museum's forthcoming building has just installed its first installation: a photo sculpture by local artist Todd Gray. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Competing views of fighting crime

Newsom's use of CHP counters Trumpian force with finesse, Anita Chabria writes. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny, very warm.
L.A. Basin: 92/72. **B5**

Opinion Voices **A11**
Obituaries **B6**

Giuliani injured in car crash

Ex-New York mayor fractures vertebra as vehicle is struck from behind. **NATION, A5**

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COLUMN ONE

7-Eleven? South Korea's style is more like 7 times Eleven

Convenience stores in the country sell cocktails, gold bars and up to 70 new food items each week

By Max Kim | REPORTING FROM SEOUL

In many parts of the world, convenience stores are the shops of last resort: cigarettes, sodas and laundry detergent. But in South Korea, you might find single-malt whiskies, \$800 French wines, 24K gold bars, shampoo and conditioner refill stations, televisions or a dine-in instant noodle bar with more than 200 varieties of ramyon. A customer might be able to pick up a package, wash and dry their clothes, or sign up for a new debit card. The stores are best known for their numerous feats of "instant-izing" food, a process in which nearly every conceivable dish is turned into a packaged meal: spaghetti, Japanese udon, fried rice that you squeeze out of a tube. These have turned convenience stores into a \$25-billion industry in South Korea, and those food products are churned out at a staggering pace: Up to 70 new food items hit the shelves each week, in effect offering a live feed of South Korean tastes. "In South Korea's food retail market,

you go extinct if you're not quick to change," says Chae Da-in, who adds that her obsession with convenience stores is decades old. "It's all about being diverse and fast." Known in the national media and on social media as a "convenience store critic," Chae is the author of three books on the world of convenience store foods, which has led to TV appearances and newspaper interviews. Every Friday, she tours a handful of convenience stores near her home to keep up with what's new. Over the last two decades, she estimates, she has consumed at least 800 varieties of convenience store samgak gimhap — rice wrapped in dried seaweed and a grab-and-go staple. In recent years, Chae has watched her obsession go global. Much like South Korean movies, TV shows and music, South Korean convenience stores have become a cultural sensation. Specific locations, such as the store [See Stores, A4]